

East India companies

In 1600, European countries founded East India companies to trade in India. England's company set up forts at Madras, Bombay, and Calcutta and began to trade in textiles. The English used the company to rule India, making alliances with local princes and driving out French colonists. Portugal also set up an Indian colony at Goa.



Figure is finely carved and painted.

Gilt

Statue of Portuguese East India Officer

British India

In the late 1700s, the British East India Company defeated rival European colonists and established an empire based on the three "presidencies" of Bombay, Madras, and Bengal. By 1850, the company ruled some three-fifths of India, with the rest run by local princes who were subject to the British.



Indian mutiny

In 1857–58, there was a mutiny of Indian troops in the British army, arising from British insensitivity to Indian customs and religions. The rebels took large areas of India, but the British soon regained the territory, restoring order by July 1858, after much bloodshed.



The British parliament took a greater part in Indian government after the mutiny.

British rule

After the Indian mutiny, the British disbanded the East India Company. The British adopted a more positive attitude towards the Indian people. A new government department was formed and an official called a Viceroy ruled on behalf of the crown. However, the Indian people remained far poorer than the British.



Building the railway system in India

Rise of industry

During the 19th century, India became an industrialized country. The British built Asia's largest rail network in India, and developed steamship and telegraph services. India exported raw materials to British factories, but also built its own steel and textile mills.

Independence

In 1885, the Indian National Congress was founded to campaign for Indian rights. By the 1920s, under the leadership of Mohandas Gandhi, it was demanding Indian independence. A long campaign of resistance to British rule followed, but it was not until the end of World War II, in 1945, that Britain agreed to make India an independent state.

Nehru

Jawaharlal Nehru (1889–1964) was one of the leaders of the Indian National Congress and was imprisoned nine times for his political activities. In 1947, after India's independence, he became India's first prime minister. He funded industry and developed India's role as a superpower. Nehru's daughter, Indira Gandhi, became prime minister in 1966.



Regional superpower

Under Nehru, India avoided alliances with major states. This policy of non-alignment gave India great power in its own right, power which increased when India supported East Pakistan in its civil war with West Pakistan in 1971.

Chemical works, India

Pakistan

During World War II, the Muslim League, led by Muhammad Jinnah, demanded a separate independent Muslim state in the Indian subcontinent. In 1947, the Muslim country of Pakistan was created, originally in two parts. In 1971, after a war between the two parts, East Pakistan became the independent state of Bangladesh.



First Indian National Congress

Congress Party

The Indian National Congress had led India's independence movement. After 1947, it became the Congress Party. It controlled India for much of the period after independence, under the leadership largely of members of Nehru's family: Nehru himself (prime minister 1947–64), his daughter Indira Gandhi (1966–77; 1980–84), and her son Rajiv (1984–89).

Timeline

c.2500 BC Rise of the Indus Valley civilization.

c.1600 BC Aryan nomads invade western India.

326 BC Alexander the Great invades the Punjab.

324–320 BC Mauryan dynasty.



320–c.700 Gupta Empire.

711 First Muslim invasions of India.

1206–1526 Sultans of Delhi rule northern India.

Terracotta Mother Goddess figure from Mohenjo-daro, Indus Valley civilization.

1526–1707 The Mughal Empire is established and reaches its peak.

1600 British East India Company is founded.

1746 War between British and French colonists in India.

1858 Indian mutiny defeated; British impose direct rule.



Mohandas Gandhi, campaigner for independence

1917–44 Mohandas Gandhi leads campaign of resistance to British rule.

1947 India and Pakistan become independent.

1971 New state of Bangladesh formed.

1990s Efficient agricultural methods provide India with a healthier economy.

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ALEXANDER THE GREAT

EMPIRES

GANDHI, MOHANDAS

GUPTA EMPIRE

INDUS VALLEY CIVILIZATION

MAURYAN EMPIRE

MUGHAL EMPIRE

UNITED KINGDOM, HISTORY OF